

The Cloud Caravan

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Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Girl Who Steered by Stars

Nia had been piloting the Caravan for exactly one year, six months, and fourteen days, and she kept count the way most people keep count of birthdays — because every day felt like a celebration she didn't want to miss.

The Caravan was not easy to describe to people who hadn't seen it. Imagine a carpet the size of a barn floor, deep crimson and threaded with gold, stitched through with tiny compasses that actually pointed north when the wind agreed to cooperate. On top of the carpet sat a cart — not a horse-drawn cart, not a motor cart, but something between a cottage and a library and a dream someone had forgotten to stop dreaming. Its walls were shelves. Its shelves were books. Its books were full of worlds, and the worlds were full of people waiting to be found.

Nia piloted from the bow: a small wooden platform where she stood with her feet apart and her arms wide, reading the cloud formations the way a sailor reads waves. She wore her navigator's coat — bronze buttons, deep blue wool, a pocket on the left breast specifically for emergency chocolate — and a pair of goggles that had been her grandmother's and smelled faintly of cinnamon and far-off rain.

"Northeast," said Drift.

Drift was a cloud fox — which meant he was roughly the size of a medium dog, made entirely of condensed cloud-stuff, and able to change his density from light mist to something you could almost lean against. He sat on the port rail and let his tail drift in the slipstream, watching the sky with the particular satisfaction of someone who has nowhere else to be.

"I know," Nia said. "I can see the Thornberry Shelf."

"You see seven clouds and a weather system. I smell the shelf. Northeast."

Nia adjusted the tiller. The Caravan banked gently, its carpet-edge curling slightly in the turn, and the books in the shelves swayed together like a slow tide. Somewhere in the back of the cart, a loose book fell open with a sigh, and the pages fanned themselves for a moment before settling, which was normal. The Caravan liked to read itself.

The Thornberry Shelf was a floating archipelago of flat-topped clouds, each one wide enough to park a Caravan and stable enough to hold a village, which was exactly what happened to them. Three hundred meters below, the real world carried on: roads and rooftops and rivers and all the people who hadn't yet looked up. Nia looked up always. It was an occupational requirement.

"First village by sunset," Drift said.

Nia pressed her hand to the tiller and felt the Caravan answer, warm and willing. "Then let's not be late."

Chapter 2 — Drift and the Question He Wouldn't Answer

There were things Nia knew about Drift and things she was still figuring out. She knew he liked rain from the east better than rain from the west. She knew he refused to read sad chapter endings alone, that he would nudge a book

shut with his nose just before the last paragraph and wait for Nia to sit beside him. She knew he could run along cloud surfaces without sinking through, and that when he wanted to be invisible he could reduce himself to a mist so fine you'd breathe him in without noticing.

What she didn't know was where he had come from.

She asked him about it on Tuesday, the way she asked about it every few weeks — casually, while coiling rope on the port side, as if it were a small question and not the one that sat at the center of everything.

"Before the Caravan," she said. "Were you just — flying around? Were you part of a cloud? Were you somebody's—"

"I was between," Drift said.

"Between what?"

"Things." He twitched his tail. "Stories, mostly."

Nia considered this. The Caravan hummed around them, pages rustling in the morning thermals. "What kind of stories?"

Drift was quiet for long enough that a small blue bird landed on his back, mistook him for a cloud, and nested there contentedly for approximately forty seconds before realizing its error. He watched it fly away without comment.

"The kind that needed a reader," he finally said. "The kind that were sitting alone on shelves in the middle of nothing, waiting for someone to find them and say: I see you. You matter."

Nia stopped coiling the rope. "And you were looking for them?"

"I was one of them." He said it simply, the way people say true things — without decoration, without apology. "Until you found the Caravan. Until you put your hand on the tiller and it recognized you. And then I had somewhere to be."

Nia was eleven years old and not easily surprised, but she sat down on the deck and looked at her cloud fox for a long moment. He looked back with amber eyes that held whole weather systems.

"You could have just said hello on the first day," she said at last.

"I did. You thought I was a weather phenomenon."

"You were sitting on my compass."

"It was warm." He yawned, showing neat rows of teeth that briefly sparkled like frost. "Northeast. Don't miss the Thornberry approach."

Nia stood and took the tiller. But she kept thinking about it — about stories that sat alone in the middle of nothing, waiting to be found — and she thought about it for the rest of the day.

Chapter 3 — The Village of Cumulus Cross

The village of Cumulus Cross sat on three neighboring clouds that had drifted so close together over the years that the villagers had eventually built bridges between them, and then markets on the bridges, and then schools on the platforms between the markets, until the whole structure was less three clouds and more one continuous neighborhood that happened to be seven hundred feet in the air.

The children came running when the Caravan sailed in.

This was Nia's favorite part of every arrival: the moment before anyone knew exactly what she carried. They saw the carpet and the cart and Drift on the bow, and they crowded onto the landing platform with wide eyes and questions tumbling out before she had even tied off the mooring line.

"Is it a real library?"

"Can we borrow things?"

"What's the fox made of?"

"Can he shape-shift?"

"I'm made of weather," Drift said, which answered two questions and raised fourteen more.

Nia set up in the village square — unrolling the Caravan's side panels so the shelves opened outward like pages of a book, each one displaying its titles and inviting hands. She lit the lanterns on the crossbars, amber and warm, and put out the reading cushions in a half-moon arrangement around the cart's base. The cushions were embroidered with story scenes: a dragon reading a newspaper, three rabbits solving a math equation, a girl climbing stairs made of words.

"The Traveling Library of the Cloud Caravan is open," she announced, which was the official thing to say, and then added — because Nia believed in the unofficial things too — "and everything in here is for everyone."

The children came first. Then curious teenagers pretending they were only there to supervise the children. Then adults who appeared to browse and wound up sitting down with a book and a cushion and the expression of someone returning to something they had almost lost.

An old woman named Vesper came last. She walked with a cane carved from driftwood and moved as if she had all the time in the sky.

"The old Caravan," she said, running her fingers along the cart's carved edge. "I remember when it came through forty years ago. Same carpet. Different pilot."

Nia looked up from shelving a returned book. "My grandmother."

Vesper smiled slowly. "She was a good reader. Good pilots always are." She looked at Nia with clear, steady eyes. "Watch your chapter endings tonight. The wind has been strange lately. Stories have been coming in — incomplete."

"What do you mean, incomplete?"

But a crowd of small children had swarmed Vesper's ankles with questions, and she was swept away before she could answer. Nia filed the warning in the same pocket as her emergency chocolate, and tried not to worry.

She worried anyway.

Chapter 4 — What the Storm Took

It happened that night.

Nia was reading aloud on the Caravan's deck — the third chapter of a story about a lighthouse keeper who collected echoes — when the wind changed. Not the ordinary change of direction, not the shift that made Drift's ears flatten and the Caravan rock on its moorings. This was something else: a deliberate taking, a swiping motion, as if something enormous and invisible reached down and simply removed the last three pages of the book from her hands.

Not removed. Pulled the words off the pages. She held the pages and they were there — paper, binding, cover — but the text on the final chapters had gone pale, then faint, then invisible, until she was holding blank paper in a shape that had been a story.

The lanterns guttered. Drift stood up from his sleeping position and his fur crackled with static electricity.

"It's here," he said.

"What is?"

He didn't answer immediately, which told Nia more than words would have. She reached for the tiller instinctively, though the Caravan was moored and going nowhere.

The wind came through the square like something grieving — not cold exactly, but hollow. It moved through the cushions and turned the pages of every open book, and wherever it passed, the endings disappeared. Chapter endings, story conclusions, final lines. All the sentences that said: and this is how it turned out. All the paragraphs that said: they found their way home. The wind took them, and left behind a hundred beginnings going nowhere, stories without resolution, narratives hung mid-air like questions with no one to answer them.

By morning, every book that had been open was now incomplete.

Nia stood in the village square at dawn with Vesper and a dozen worried villagers and a Drift who was slowly,

carefully, reconstructing his thoughts.

"It's the Nameless Wind," Vesper said, as if she had expected this.

"There's no such thing," said a man named Osbert, who kept goats on Cloud Three.

"There was a wind," Vesper said carefully, "that once had a name. A long name, full of movement and direction, the kind of name that told you where it had been and where it was going. And then, gradually, over years of being neither listened to nor remembered — it forgot the name. And a wind that has forgotten its name is a wind that has forgotten its purpose. It roams. And where it roams, it takes endings, because endings are what it has lost."

Nia thought about Drift's words from the day before. Stories that sat alone in the middle of nothing.

"Can it be helped?" she asked.

Vesper looked at her for a long moment. "That," she said, "is exactly the right question."

Chapter 5 — The Map That Changed Its Mind

Finding the Nameless Wind was not like finding a city or a road. It was more like finding a feeling that kept moving.

Nia laid out every navigation chart the Caravan carried on the main table inside the cart — thirty-seven charts in all, ranging from ordinary cloud-archipelago maps to a hand-drawn sketch her grandmother had labeled PLACES THAT ONLY EXIST WHEN YOU'RE LOOKING FOR SOMETHING ELSE. Drift walked across the maps with light feet, his cloud-body leaving faint damp impressions on the paper wherever he paused.

"It moved west last night after the square," Drift said.

"How do you know?"

"I can feel it. It's like — a gap in the air. Like a question walking around in the shape of a wind." He paused at the hand-drawn sketch. His paw rested on a section labeled The Hollow Sky. "It goes back here. I think it's trying to remember something. Or trying to find something to give it back."

Nia studied the Hollow Sky. On her grandmother's map it was drawn with careful uncertainty — the borders were dotted rather than solid, the label written in smaller script than everywhere else, as if it might change if you looked too hard. "That's three days northeast of here."

"If it's traveling at current speed, two and a half."

"What do we find when we get there?"

Drift was quiet. Outside, villagers were already coming to the cart, distressed about their books, asking what could be done with chapters that had lost their endings. Nia could hear their voices — not angry, but bewildered,

the tone of people who have found a gap where something used to be and don't quite know what to put there instead.

"I don't know what we find," Drift admitted. "But I think the map does."

Nia looked down. The hand-drawn sketch had shifted. She blinked and looked again. It had definitely shifted — the Hollow Sky was still there, but beside it, in ink that had not existed ten minutes ago, was a small careful drawing of a reading circle: six figures sitting together with books open on their laps, and a seventh figure standing at the center, arms spread wide.

Her grandmother's handwriting appeared below it, faint as old memory, but legible: The story needs community to complete. One voice is not enough. You will need more.

"Well," Nia said. "At least the map is on our side."

She rolled up the charts and took the tiller.

Chapter 6 — The Floating Villages Listen

They spent the next two days visiting every village on the Thornberry Shelf — not just Cumulus Cross, but the Woolen Market of Shelf Four, the twin villages of Updown and Downup on Shelf Seven, the quiet reading retreat of Stillpoint that floated so gently above the others that most people forgot it was there.

At every stop, Nia heard the same story. Books missing their endings. Stories that had been passed down through generations — told at bedtime, read aloud at festivals, shared in that particular intimate way that makes a story belong to many people at once — now truncated. Cut short. The Nameless Wind had been thorough.

But she also heard something else.

At the Woolen Market, she met a boy named Clem who had memorized the ending of his favorite story before it was taken. He recited it to her with his eyes closed and his fists clenched, as if holding on with his whole body, and every word was perfect.

At Stillpoint, an elderly couple named Rue and Hannish had written down the endings of stories they could remember, in their own words, in a weathered notebook, because they thought someone might need them.

At Updown, a group of children had invented new endings for stories that had lost theirs — drawing them in pictures, acting them out in short plays, narrating them to each other in the slow serious voices of people who understand that stories have weight and must be handled carefully.

Nia collected all of it. She wrote down Clem's recitation. She borrowed Rue and Hannish's notebook. She watched the children's plays and took notes and asked questions and sat with people in their homes and kitchens and on cloud-edge benches, listening.

Drift stayed close. He let the smaller children pet his cloud-fur, which made their hands cold and sparkling, and he

told them small stories of his own — brief ones, only a few sentences, but always with a complete ending, clear and honest and specific. He did this deliberately, Nia noticed. He was demonstrating something.

"They're hungry for endings," she said one evening, mooring the Caravan above Stillpoint while the sun set orange and violet across the cloud-tops.

"Everyone is," Drift said. "The not-knowing is the hardest part."

"Is that why the Nameless Wind keeps taking them? Because it doesn't know its own ending?"

He looked at her steadily. "I think the wind is doing what it knows: searching. It doesn't understand that the search is hurting other people. It only knows what it lost."

Nia thought about that for a long time as the stars came out, one by one, very patient and very bright.

"Then," she said finally, "we need to teach it something it doesn't know."

Chapter 7 — Into the Hollow Sky

Two and a half days of hard northeast sailing brought the Caravan to the edge of the Hollow Sky, and Nia immediately understood why her grandmother had drawn it with uncertain borders.

It was not a place in the ordinary sense. It was a region of sky where clouds moved differently — not carried on wind, but circling slowly, continuously, like thoughts going over and over the same point without resolution. The clouds here were colorless, or nearly so, all pale silver and grey, and they muffled sound so that even Drift's voice felt closer and quieter, as if the air itself was listening.

"Eerie," Nia said.

"Yes," Drift agreed, which was not reassuring coming from a creature made of weather.

She sailed slowly, watching the carpet-compass. North here was inconsistent, swinging by five or ten degrees in either direction, as if the Hollow Sky had its own magnetism that couldn't quite decide. The books in the Caravan's shelves had gone very still — which was unusual, since they typically rustled and shifted at the slightest air current. Now they stood pressed together, quiet, as if they were trying to make themselves small.

"The wind is here," Drift said. He had reduced himself to a dense silver mist, almost invisible, matching the air around them. His voice came from approximately three feet to Nia's left. "I can feel it. It's — big. Bigger than a wind should be, because it's been building for a long time. All those missing endings — it's carrying them."

"It's been collecting endings?"

"Not on purpose. It's like how water collects in a low place. The wind moves through endings and takes them without knowing it takes them, because endings are heavy with meaning and meaning has weight, and a wind without direction collects weight as it goes."

Nia steadied the tiller. The pale clouds circled. Then, slowly, one of them stopped circling and turned toward the Caravan.

It was not a cloud exactly — it was more organized than a cloud, more intentional, with something like a shape inside it, vast and restless and old. It did not speak. It moved.

And when it moved, the Caravan shuddered. Books fell from the shelves. Pages riffled open. Nia felt words pull away from her memory — not important words, not her own name or Drift's name or her grandmother's face, but small story-words: the ending of a poem she had learned at age six, the last line of a tale she had read on a rainy afternoon in a house that smelled of soup and rosemary.

"Hey," she said. Not angry. Clear. "I see you."

The pale shape stopped moving.

Nia held steady at the tiller. Her heart was going fast, but her hands were still. "I see you," she said again, "and I know what you lost."

Chapter 8 — What the Wind Remembered

The Nameless Wind listened.

This was, Drift told Nia afterward, extraordinary. Winds do not typically listen. They move, they carry, they scatter — but listening requires stillness, and stillness requires, for a wind, enormous effort. That the Nameless Wind held its position in the Hollow Sky and did not scatter the Caravan into pieces meant that some part of it, however buried under years of wandering and forgetting, still wanted to understand.

Nia talked to it the way she talked to the Caravan — steadily, honestly, with her hands on the tiller and her eyes forward.

"You had a name," she said. "And a name means a direction, a purpose, a story about yourself. And you lost the name, and without it, you didn't know where to go or what you were doing. So you kept moving. And as you moved, you picked up the weight of everyone else's endings — all the conclusions you passed through without knowing you were taking them."

The pale shape moved, not toward her this time, but around her, a slow curious orbit. The books on the shelves stirred and opened, but gently, as if the wind was looking at them rather than taking from them.

"We can't give you your name back," Nia said. "We don't know it. But we know something that might help you find it again." She reached into her coat and brought out the notebook from Rue and Hannish, the pages of recited endings from Clem, the drawings and play-scripts from the children of Updown. She held them up. "Endings. Real ones, given willingly, from communities that love their stories. Not taken. Given."

Drift drifted closer to her shoulder, almost solid, almost warm. "Read one," he said quietly.

Nia opened the notebook to the first page. Hannish's handwriting was large and looping, full of confidence.

"And at the end of that long summer," she read, "the children returned to the lighthouse and found it lit — not by oil or electricity, but by all the stories it had heard while they were away, glowing steady and warm in its great glass eye, saying: I remembered you. You were worth waiting for."

The wind stopped its orbit.

It did not speak in words. It spoke in the way winds speak: in the movement of air, in the pressure change, in the way everything it was carrying suddenly became less turbulent. Not released — it couldn't give back what it had taken so casually — but recognized. Named. There was a sound, very faint, that might have been a name or might have been the wind learning that it had one, or might have been both things happening at exactly the same moment.

Drift pressed close against Nia's arm, and she was certain, for one clear second, that the cloud fox was crying. She did not mention it. Some true things are best held gently.

Chapter 9 — The Reading Circle Gathers

They could not fix it alone. That was the thing Nia had understood from her grandmother's map: one voice is not enough.

She sailed back through the Thornberry Shelf with a plan and three days' worth of urgency. The plan was simple. The execution was not.

A reading circle. Every village on the Shelf, every reader who could come — and not just the readers, but the listeners, the story-holders, the grandparents who kept things in memory when books could not be trusted, the children who had invented new endings because they could not bear incompleteness. Every person who had a piece of a story that needed its other pieces.

Gathering them was Nia's job. Organizing was Drift's — he proved, much to her surprise, extraordinarily good at logistics. He knew which cloud-villages had bridges between them and which required fly-across; he calculated the capacity of the wide platform at Cumulus Cross and determined it could hold two hundred people if you arranged the seating carefully; he drafted the messages that went out on the wind to every village, which was somewhat ironic but entirely effective.

Clem came from the Woolen Market and brought his memorized ending and four friends who had memorized other things. Rue and Hannish came from Stillpoint and brought their notebook and two pies and an excellent blanket. The children from Updown came in a procession that took up the entire bridge between Shelves Six and Seven and moved with the organized chaos of people who are certain they belong exactly where they are going.

Vesper was already at Cumulus Cross when the Caravan arrived. She was standing in the center of the square with her driftwood cane and an air of someone who has been expecting exactly this.

"The Nameless Wind is following you," she said. "I can smell it. It's curious."

"It's coming to listen," Nia said.

Vesper looked at her for a long moment. "Your grandmother would be very pleased."

Nia felt warmth spread from the center of her chest outward, the specific warmth of being seen by someone who knew you from before you knew yourself. "I'm going to need you to open the circle," she told Vesper. "You know how."

"I've opened many circles in my time." Vesper smiled, and it was a smile like the last page of a beloved book — complete, unhurried, full of something that didn't quite have a word. "Let's begin."

Chapter 10 — Stories Given Back

Two hundred and forty-three people sat in a circle on the platform at Cumulus Cross. Plus children who couldn't sit still and sat anyway, fidgeting with contained excitement. Plus one cloud fox who circled the perimeter like a silver ribbon, keeping the shape of the gathering whole.

Nia stood at the center, not because she was the most important person there — she was fairly certain she was not — but because the Caravan was docked at the edge of the platform with its shelves open, and someone needed to stand between the people and the books, to pass things back and forth, to be the connective tissue of the circle.

Vesper opened it.

She spoke an ending first — the oldest ending she knew, learned from her own grandmother: a story about three brothers who built a bridge between two clouds and in doing so built a bridge between themselves. Her voice was clear and steady, and every person in the circle leaned forward slightly as she spoke.

Then Clem recited his ending, eyes closed, fists unclenched this time, arms at his sides, the words coming out of him as natural as breath.

Then Rue read from the notebook, and Hannish read after her. The children from Updown enacted their play — wordlessly, through gesture, which turned out to be more moving than words might have been.

And then people Nia didn't know began to stand up. A fisherman who brought boats up to cloud-level to sell to the village markets; he remembered the ending to a storm story his father had told. A girl of about seven who had never been to this village before but had traveled three shelves to be here, because her school had a book with a missing chapter and she had been unable to sleep. A woman who taught navigation by the stars and could recite the final verses of the Cloud Mariner's Journey from memory, her voice low and exact.

Story by story. Ending by ending.

The Nameless Wind moved through the gathering — not violently, not taking. It moved the way it might have moved once, a long time ago, when it had a name and a direction: curious, alive, present. People felt it on their faces and didn't flinch. Drift ran alongside it, just visible, leading it gently through the words like a guide through a forest.

The books on the Caravan's shelves began to fill.

Not all of them. Not at once. But pages that had been blank began to show faint text, as if writing was remembering itself. Chapter endings returned, not word-for-word in every case, but true — honestly true, emotionally complete, narratively whole. The stories were not identical to what had been taken. They were something the community had given back, and they had the texture of many voices all saying the same important thing.

It went on for three hours. No one left early.

Chapter 11 — The Wind Finds Its Name

The name came at dusk, and it came from the smallest person there.

Her name was Pip, and she was five years old, and she had not recited an ending or read from a notebook or performed a play. She had sat at the edge of the circle for three hours with her legs folded and her hands in her lap and her eyes tracking the pale shape of the Nameless Wind as it moved through the gathering, invisible to almost everyone, visible to her the way things are visible to people who have not yet learned to stop seeing them.

As the last story-ending was given — the fisherman's storm story, the father's words returned to the world — Pip stood up. She was very small in the circle of two hundred and forty-three people, but she had a voice with unexpected carrying power.

"I know your name," she said. "I heard it."

The Nameless Wind stilled. The platform at Cumulus Cross went completely quiet — not the quiet of people trying to be quiet, but the quiet of everything pausing at once, the kind of silence that happens when the world is paying attention.

"I heard it in the stories," Pip continued. She frowned slightly, working through something difficult. "Not one story. All of them together. Like when all the notes play at once and you hear the chord. Your name is in the chord."

Drift was completely still on the far side of the circle. Vesper had put a hand over her heart.

Nia held her breath.

Pip opened her mouth and said a word that was not exactly a word — it was more like a weather event, a small contained one, the kind of sound that happens when the first warm air of spring meets the last cold of winter and neither one wins exactly, but something new is made. The people nearest to her felt it on their skin. The books in the Caravan rustled, every single one, simultaneously.

The Nameless Wind became, very briefly, visible: silver and vast, older than any of the cloud-villages, older perhaps than the clouds themselves, full of everything it had carried all those years — not lost endings anymore, but the gift of them, held.

And then it moved.

Not aimlessly. Purposefully. With direction. With, for the first time in a very long time, a name to move toward.

It swept outward from the platform of Cumulus Cross in a spiral, warm and clean, and as it went it left behind every missing ending — not tucked back in the exact words they had been taken in, but scattered gently over every roof and railing of the Thornberry Shelf, so that when people opened their books the next morning, they found something written in the margins: a completion, a final note, a hand reaching through the end of the chapter to say: it's all right. We found each other.

Pip sat back down and ate a biscuit.

"How did you hear it?" Nia asked her, when she could find words.

Pip shrugged with the total nonchalance of a five-year-old who has just done something magnificent. "I listened to all of them together," she said. "That's what you do."

Chapter 12 — The Library Carries On

Three mornings after the reading circle at Cumulus Cross, the Caravan set sail again.

It was the kind of morning that begins as if it has been waiting patiently for you to wake up: sky so clean and blue it looked polished, cloud-tops glowing faint gold at the edges, the whole Thornberry Shelf spread out below them like a thought the world was still having. Drift stood at the bow with his tail raised and his ears forward, reading the weather the way he always did — not just for information, but for pleasure.

"South," he said. "Three cloud-villages that haven't seen the Caravan in six months. Then east to the Cirrus Library for resupply."

Nia was going through the shelves, cataloging. The books were all accounted for, all complete, and several of them seemed heavier than before — richer, somehow, the way food from a shared table feels different from food eaten alone. She ran her fingers along the spines and felt them hum under her hands.

"Drift," she said. "When the wind found its name — where did it go?"

"Where winds go," he said. "Everywhere. In all its proper directions." A pause. "It'll still move through stories. That doesn't change. But now it knows what it's doing. It's not taking anymore. It's — carrying."

"Carrying endings?"

"Carrying them forward. Helping stories travel." He looked back at her over his shoulder, amber eyes calm and certain. "That's what a named wind does. It knows its purpose."

Nia thought about that as she took the tiller and the Caravan lifted from the Cumulus Cross moorings into the wide morning sky. Below, on the platform, a small figure waved — Pip, who had been given a biscuit tin and a

picture book and the knowledge that she had done something that would never quite be undone, for which she seemed entirely satisfied. Beside her, Vesper raised her driftwood cane in a slow, dignified salute.

Clem was on the bridge between Shelves Three and Four, and he waved too, both arms, completely without embarrassment. The fisherman at his cloud-edge stall paused in his work and nodded. Rue and Hannish were visible on Stillpoint's platform, two small figures side by side, and Hannish had clearly written something very large on a piece of paper and was holding it up: SAFE TRAVELS. COME BACK.

Nia waved at all of them until they were too small to see. She kept her hand raised even then, a moment longer.

"Ready?" Drift said.

"Always," she said.

The Caravan banked south, its carpet-compass spinning to settle, its shelves full and willing, its lanterns lit against the morning. Below, on the Thornberry Shelf, people were opening books and finding endings where there had been blank pages, and reading them aloud to each other, and smiling the particular smile of someone who has received exactly the right thing at exactly the right time.

Above, a warm, purposeful wind moved south with the Caravan for a little while, and then turned east because that was where it was going next, and that was fine. Names give you direction. Stories give you somewhere to go. And all across the floating villages of the cloud sky, the morning was full of both.

THE END